

closest friends, and they all just happen to bring their checkbooks and leave little love gifts for George Bush, then I guess you can say that you are indeed special.

America is the land of the free and the home of the brave; unfortunately, it is also the home of the advantaged and spoiled and “special.” Do I want to put the kibosh on their deceptive practices? Yes, I do. And I state that up front and honestly. I don’t hide in the fine print and legalese.

The credit card companies are in a class by themselves when it comes to manipulating the terms of their contracts. In an interview for the PBS documentary, *Secret History of Credit Cards*, Harvard law professor, Elizabeth Warren, has pointed out that the credit card industry is the only one able to run a business like this. “Nobody signs contracts to buy things that say, ‘I’m going to pay you \$1,200 for the big-screen TV unless you decide, in another month or two months, that it should really be \$3,600 or \$4,200 or \$4,800.’ But that’s precisely how credit card contracts are written today.”

Crazy contracts, yes. Crazy consumer, no. It’s time to play a new game called, “Let’s Get a Better Rate.”

Rate Switch

If you want to get better telephone rates, you call them up and ask. If you don’t like their deal, you switch providers. You are not afraid to call your cable company and ask if HBO is on special this month. You know to never ever take the first offer that the car salesman gives you, so why are we all so intimidated by the credit card companies?

Maybe many of us had no idea what they were really up to. Blind trust is now shattered. Maybe we feel it is futile. They have gotten away with it for so long, it is all we know. We have taken our beatings and have decided to stay down on the mat. One thing that I have learned in my life is that staying down, or remaining quiet, only leads them to believe that they are in control, and then they will only try to get away with more. They think their tricks are top-secret or untouchable. Wrong.

We can pull the plug on the runaway interest rates and fees. We can cut our debt in up to half by doing so! And it all starts with a simple phone call.